

Every Nose, Every Skin

Allergens, skin chemistry, and why "one signature scent for everyone" was never true

Learning Objectives

- Identify common fragrance allergens and sensitivities requiring caution
- Explain how skin chemistry and pH affect how a fragrance develops on different people
- Adapt fragrance and ubtan recommendations for sensitive or reactive skin
- Explain why the same bottle can smell noticeably different on two different clients

Same bottle, different skin, different scent

A fragrance is not a fixed object — it is a chemical reaction between the product and the individual skin it meets. Oilier skin tends to hold and amplify fragrance longer than drier skin, and each person's unique skin chemistry, diet, and even medication can shift how a note reads once applied. This is why a scent a client loved on a friend can smell entirely different, sometimes disappointingly so, on her own skin — never treat this as the product failing.

Common fragrance allergens

Certain aromatic compounds are recognised, well-documented triggers for contact dermatitis and allergic reaction in a meaningful minority of clients — synthetic musks in some formulations, specific essential oils including bergamot and cinnamon, and certain preservative compounds used in fragrance manufacturing. Industry bodies such as IFRA (the International Fragrance Association) publish restricted and regulated-use guidance for exactly this reason; treat any documented allergen with the same seriousness Course VI's mehndi module treated PPD.

Ubtan sensitivity

Turmeric, the base of most ubtan formulations, can cause a temporary yellow stain on very fair or reactive skin and, rarely, a genuine allergic reaction. Gram flour (besan), another core ubtan ingredient, is chickpea-derived and must be avoided entirely for any client disclosing a legume or chickpea allergy — always ask directly rather than assuming a "natural" ingredient carries no risk.

Key Terms

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Practical Activity · The Allergen Audit

Review the ingredient list of three fragrance or ubtan products and identify any documented allergens present, cross-referencing against this module's reference guide.